BUILDSTACK GUIDE

How to use someone else's GitHub repo

A plain-English guide for beginners. No coding background needed.

First: what is a repo?

A **repo** (short for repository) is a project folder that lives on GitHub. It holds all the files for something someone built (code, instructions, images) plus the full history of every change.

Think of it like a shared Google Drive folder that remembers every edit ever made. Anyone can look inside a public repo, and most let you copy and use what's there.

> The most important file is the **README**. It shows up on the repo's front page and is the instruction manual. **Always read the README first.**

The 3 ways people use a repo

1. Download it and run it yourself

Copy the whole folder to your computer and run it. Click the green **Code** button → **Download ZIP**, or "clone" it with git, which keeps a live link so you can pull updates later:

```
git clone https://github.com/OWNER/REPO.git
```

Then the README tells you how to start it (often `npm install` then `npm start`). Best for apps and websites you want to run or change.

2. Install it as a package, skill, or MCP server

Many repos aren't meant to be opened at all. They're add-ons you plug into another tool with one command from the README: an npm package, a **skill** for Claude, or an **MCP server** (a connector that gives an AI agent new abilities, like controlling a browser). You never touch the code.

3. Hand it to an AI agent

The easiest way. Open an AI coding agent like **Claude Code** and paste the link with what you want:

```
Here's a repo: https://github.com/OWNER/REPO
Read the README, set it up on my computer, and show me how to use it.
```

The agent reads the instructions, runs the commands, and explains what it did. Check the repo is trustworthy first (see below), because the agent will do whatever the repo's instructions say.

Walkthrough: install Anthropic's skills into Claude Code

anthropics/skills (github.com/anthropics/skills) is #2 on the BuildStack MCP & Skills Top 100. It's Anthropic's official collection of **skills**: folders of instructions that teach Claude specific jobs like working with PDFs, Word docs, and spreadsheets. These steps come straight from its README.

1. **Open Claude Code** in your terminal.
2. **Add the repo as a plugin marketplace** by typing this inside Claude Code:

   ```
   /plugin marketplace add anthropics/skills
   ```

3. **Pick what to install:** Browse and install plugins → anthropic-agent-skills → document-skills or example-skills → Install now. Or skip the menus:

   ```
   /plugin install document-skills@anthropic-agent-skills
   /plugin install example-skills@anthropic-agent-skills
   ```

4. **Use it** by mentioning the skill in plain English:

   ```
   Use the PDF skill to extract the form fields from path/to/some-file.pdf
   ```

No downloading, no code. On a paid Claude.ai plan, the README says these example skills are already available.

What to check before you trust a repo

Anyone can put anything on GitHub. Spend 60 seconds on these first:

- **Who made it?** The name before the slash is the owner. `anthropics/skills` is Anthropic's official account. Watch for look-alikes.
- **Stars** ⭐ are bookmarks from other people. As of Oct 16, 2026, anthropics/skills has about 181,000. It's a popularity signal, not a safety guarantee; stars can be bought.
- **Last commit:** the date at the top of the file list. Recent = maintained. Years old = may be broken.
- **License** says what you're allowed to do. MIT/Apache 2.0 = free to use. No license = technically no permission. Some repos mix licenses: anthropics/skills says many skills are Apache 2.0, but the document skills are "source-available, not open source."
- **Issues tab:** are problems reported, and does anyone answer?
- **Read what it will run.** Be careful with anything asking for passwords or API keys, or a pasted `curl ... | bash` command.

Quick recap

> • A repo is a project folder on GitHub. The README is the manual.
> • Use it by downloading/cloning, installing it as an add-on, or handing the link to an AI agent.
> • Check owner, stars, last commit, and license before you trust it.

From BuildStack: AI tools for builders · buildstack-fawn.vercel.app · Find repos worth trying in the weekly MCP & Skills Top 100: buildstack-fawn.vercel.app/top100